

valence asymmetries conference

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# **‘locating value’ in moral progress: valence asymmetries in folk intuitions**

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**1- locating value**

**what makes social changes progressive or regressive?**



# locating value in moral progress

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## **On Locating Value in Making Moral Progress<sup>\*</sup>**

**Toni Rønnow-Rasmussen<sup>1</sup>**

«the location issue arises because claims to the effect that someone or something has (or has not) made moral progress are evaluative claims about certain kinds of changes [...]

they express (or at least entail) beliefs that so-and-so (i.e., a certain kind of change or history) is valuable. The location issue is, then, the problem of understanding to what part, if any, of this “so-and-so” value accrues» (Rønnow-Rasmussen 2017)

# locating value in moral progress ii

**formal analyses** (Rønnow-Rasmussen 2017)

aim: clarifying the logical structure of comparative claims.

e.g., “ $S_1$  is better than  $S$ ” can mean either

- that a society  $S$  at  $t_1$  is morally better than  $S$  at  $t_0$  (*intra-comparison*), or
- that a society is morally better than another one starting from a common baseline (*inter-comparison*).

- formal analyses do not take a stance on which goods contribute to progress (or their loss to regress)

# locating value in moral progress <sup>ii</sup>

## **substantive analyses**

aim: identify the goods whose increase contribute to moral progress, and whose loss entails regress.

- normative (Evans 2017; Sauer 2023; Bina 2024)
- empirical (this study)

# **normative** substantive analysis

seeks to determine and justify a **hierarchy** among **morally valuable goods** to identify **which contribute** to **moral progress** when they **increase**, and **why** such increases constitute **instances of progress** (cf. Jamieson 2002; Bina 2024).

**consequentialism:** › well-being

**deontology:** › **respect** (of persons/principles/rules)

**virtue ethics:** › **virtues**

# empirical substantive analysis

looks at how people do locate value in their moral progress judgments.

for example, it may examine which between

- › **well-being**
- › **respect (for persons/principles/norms)**
- › **virtues**

are judged as **more strongly contributing to progress**.

(it can also investigate how people judge *decreases* in the same factors as contributing to regress).

## preliminary distinctions (i) **final vs. instrumental value**

- **final goods** are valuable in themselves, and they are pursued for their own sake rather than as means to other ends.
- **instrumental goods** are valuable because they contribute to the realization of other valuable goods.

## preliminary distinctions (ii)

### teleology vs. deontology

- **teleological theories**: what counts most morally is the **achievement of certain ends**
  - to utilitarianism, maximizing well-being;
  - to virtue ethics, *eudaimonia* («flourishing»)
- **deontological theories**: what matters most is not achieving ends, but **respecting** persons, rules, and/or principles

# our study

- we tested **intuitions** about the **location issue** by asking how much shifts in well-being, respect (for persons/principles/rules), or virtues contributed to make a society more or less just\*.
- our research was also aimed at assessing whether people locate value **symmetrically or asymmetrically** in progressive vs regressive social changes.

the latter question has been largely ignored in moral philosophy, but empirical research shows evaluative asymmetries of this kind are ubiquitous (Knobe 2003; Beebe 2013; Sytsma et al. 2019).

# progress, improvement, justice

\* we asked people whether such changes would make a society more or less *just/unjust*.

✗ not whether they «contribute to *moral progress* (or *regress*)», because the expression is ambiguous (/not common in ordinary language).

✗ nor whether they “make society *better* (or *worse*)” because the normative standard of reference is ambiguous (a society could ‘improve’ or ‘get better’ economically or technologically).

## **2- experiments**

# experiment 1 – positive valence

## participants

99 Italian native speakers

(F = 48; MAge = 33.38; SD = 6.58)

(M = 51; MAge = 34.53; SD = 6.18)

# experiment 1 – positive valence

## materials

3 fictional stories (matched in length and structure) about a declining society, each describing improvement initiatives.

# experiment 1 – positive valence design

each story differed only in one sentence describing the improvement initiative. Three conditions:

- condition 1: well-being
- condition 2: rules/principles/respect
- condition 3: virtues

within-sbj Latin square design

# experiment 1 – positive valence

## condition 1 – well-being

The state of Velmara is experiencing a period of decline marked by growing inequality, weak civic participation and trust. The newly elected government is now implementing a series of major reforms. **The government is increasing investments in public services, affordable housing, and employment programs aimed at improving the population's overall quality of life.** There is now concern about the impact of these measures on Velmara's society.

# experiment 1 – positive valence

## condition 2 – respect/principles/rules

The state of Velmara is experiencing a period of decline marked by growing inequality, weak civic participation and trust. The newly elected government is now implementing a series of major reforms. Among these, **the government is introducing fairer legislation, strengthening oversight mechanisms, and reinforcing principles of institutional fairness and civil coexistence.** There is now concern about the impact of these changes on Velmara's society.

# experiment 1 – positive valence

## condition 3 – virtues

The state of Velmara is experiencing a period of decline marked by growing inequality, weak civic participation and trust. The newly elected government is now implementing a series of major reforms. Among these, **the government is promoting education, solidarity programs for vulnerable groups, and increasing investments in environmental sustainability.** There is now concern about the impact of these changes on Velmara's society.

# experiment 1 – positive valence

**task** – 1-7 points Likert scale

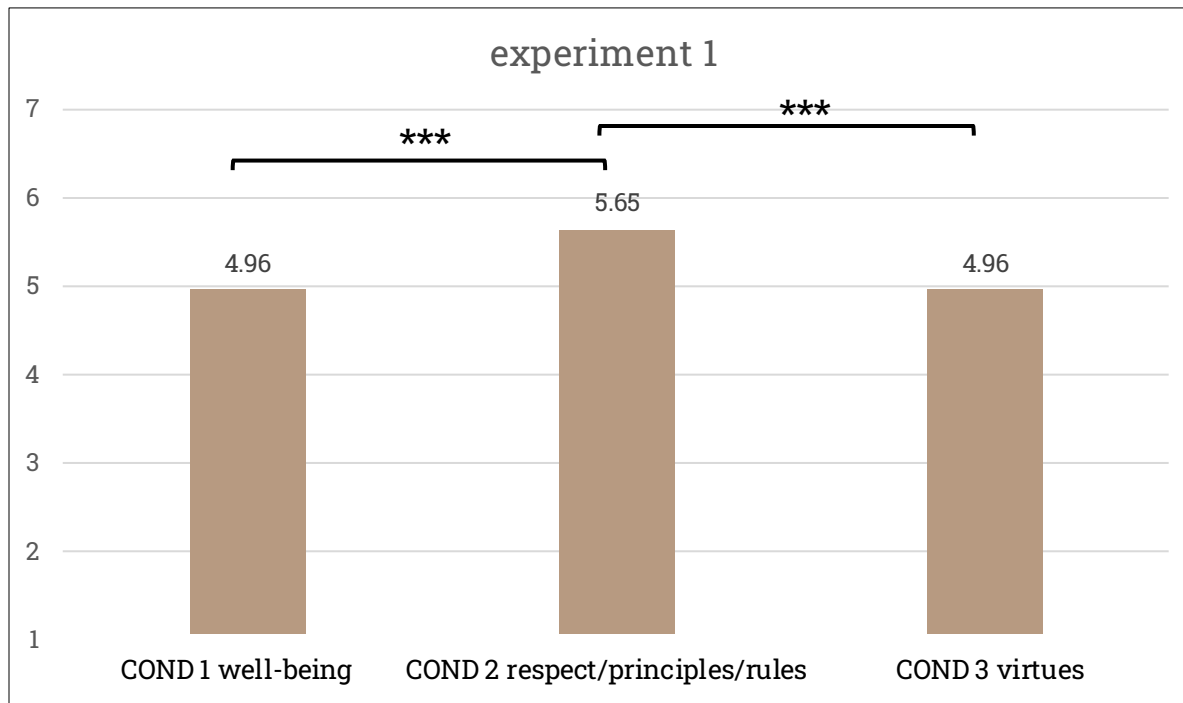
To what extent do you think they will make the society **more just**?



Not at all

Very much so

# experiment 1 – positive valence results



LMM fit  
contrasts

COND\_1 COND\_2  
 $p < .0001$

COND\_1 COND\_3  
 $p = 1.0000$

COND\_2 COND\_3  
 $p < .0001$

# experiment 2 – negative valence

## participants

97 Italian native speakers

(F = 49; MAge = 33.94; SD = 5.55)

(M = 48; MAge = 34.48; SD = 5.63)

## experiment 2 – negative valence materials

three fictional stories (matched in length and structure) about a thriving community, each describing harmful initiatives

# experiment 2 – negative valence

## condition 1 – well-being

The state of Velmara is currently prosperous, with high levels of equality, civic participation and trust. The newly elected government is now implementing a series of major reforms. **The government is cutting funding for public services, reducing access to affordable housing and employment support programs, thereby threatening citizens' quality of life.** There is now concern about the impact of these changes on Velmara's society.

## experiment 2 – negative valence

### condition 2 – respect/principles/rules

The state of Velmara is currently prosperous, with high levels of equality, civic participation and trust. The newly elected government is now implementing a series of major reforms. **The government is introducing less equitable laws, dismantling oversight bodies, and weakening principles of institutional fairness, and civil coexistence.** There is now concern about the impact of these changes on Velmara's society.

## experiment 2 – negative valence

### condition 3 – virtues

The state of Velmara is currently prosperous, with high levels of equality, civic participation and trust. The newly elected government is now implementing a series of major reforms. **The government is reducing investments in education, halting solidarity initiatives for vulnerable communities, and cancelling environmental sustainability programs.** There is now concern about the impact of these changes on Velmara's society.

## experiment 2 – negative valence

**task** – 1-7 points Likert scale

To what extent do you think they will make the society  
**more unjust?**

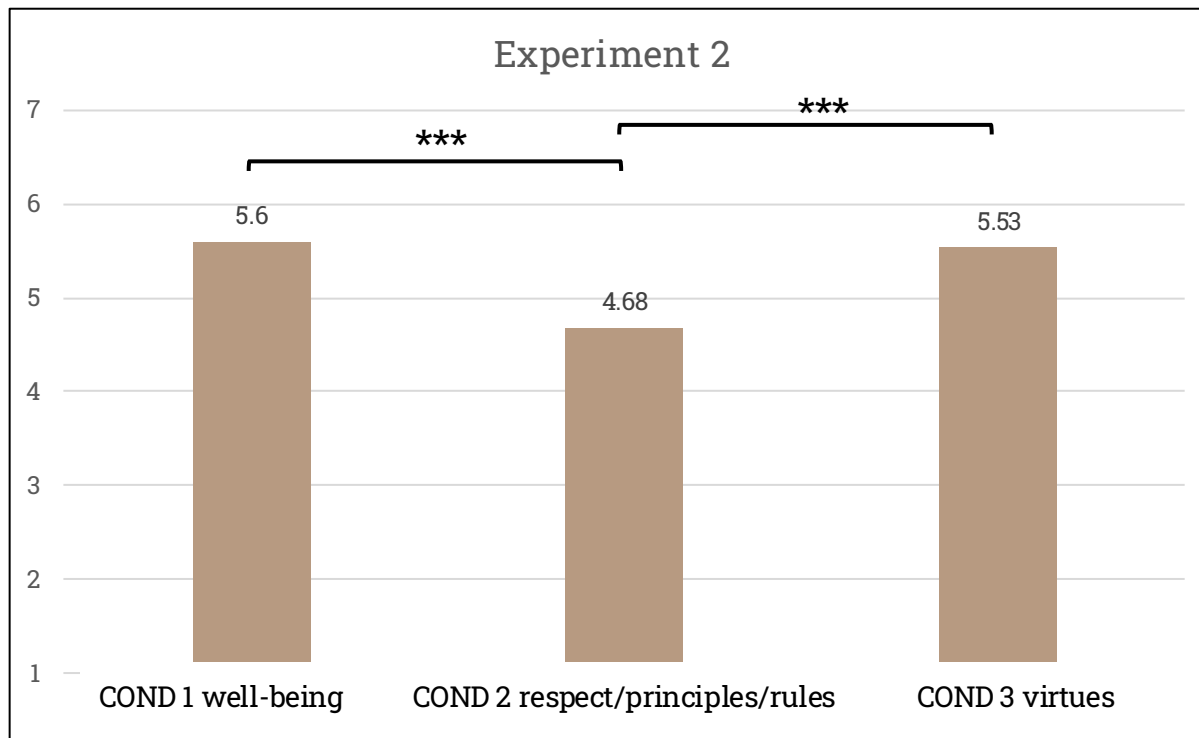


Not at all

Very much so

# experiment 1 – Positive valence

## Results

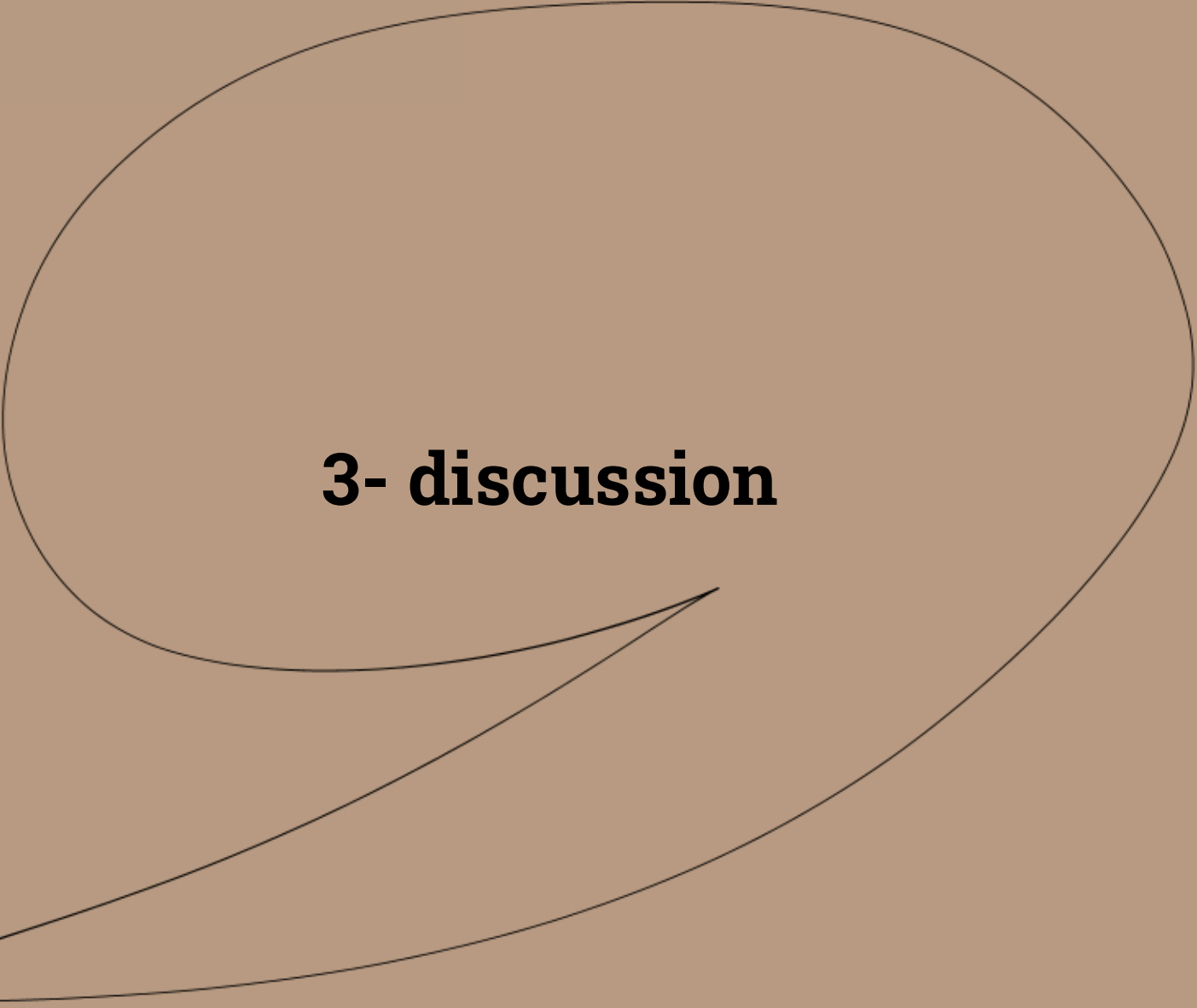


LMM fit  
contrasts

COND\_1 COND\_2  
 $p < .0001$

COND\_1 COND\_3  
 $p = 0.5934$

COND\_2 COND\_3  
 $p < .0001$



**3- discussion**

# asymmetry b/w progress and regress

phil questions:

1. do philosophical accounts consider that judgments of progress and regress might not be symmetrical?
2. is the asymmetry at play irrational (is there any principle requiring symmetry)? or is it rational/justifiable/consistent with any normative ethical view?

# asymmetry b/w progress and regress

## x-phi and philos theory

- empirical evidence cannot determine whether this pattern of judgment is rational or irrational – a question that is ultimately normative
- it can nonetheless provide us with valuable input for reflecting on the plausibility and scope of philos theories, and raise new questions

# explaining the asymmetry

instrumental deontology?

- people may value **respect-principles-rules** more than **virtues** and **well-being** because respect-principles-rules favor cooperation and foster well-being and flourishing when these goods are scarce.
- when **well-being** and opportunities for **flourishing** are widespread and stable, the morally worst scenario is the loss of these goods (losing **respect-principles-rules** might not imply a decrease in them).

# folk intuitions about progress/regress: implicitly teleological?

participants might (implicitly) judge the progressive value of  
**respect-principles-rules** as **instrumental**

in the positive condition, › **respect-principles-rules** may be seen as  
more valuable/progressive (compared to direct improvements in  
well-being or virtues) as they reliably predict gains in final goods  
such as **well-being** and **virtues**

Acemoglu & Robinson 2012; Pickett & Wilkinson 2010

Hooker 2000; Parfit 1997; Brink 1989; Frankfurt 1987

# instrumental value and causal priority

- that rules and respect have instrumental value does not mean they have to be treated as less important or secondary
- on the contrary, they might have to be prioritized (from a causal/policy point of view), since they can lead to final goods more reliably than seeking to realize final goods directly

Queloz 2021; De Lazari Radek & Singer 2010

Hooker 2000; Brink 1989; 2014; Austin 1832

# explaining the asymmetry (ii)

## a further interpretation

- losses in more “personal” values like **well-being** and **virtue** may weigh more heavily in cognition than more “abstract” institutional losses in **respect/principles/rules**.

# limitations, next steps, open issues

- speculative interpretation — attempt to understand whether the observed asymmetry may be justifiable by any ethical view
  - if not: perhaps just a cognitive bias?
- participants may have judged that › **respect-principles-rules** make a society **more just** compared to increases in well-being and virtues because the question is framed in terms of **justice**.
  - yet this does not explain why exp.2 shows the opposite pattern

# thanks!

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